

KEY EVENTS

11TH–15TH CENTURY

- **11th century** The crossbow is used in European warfare, notably by the Genoese.
- **1139** Pope Innocent II bans the crossbow (along with other bows) because of the number of Christian knights it kills. The ban is ineffectual.
- **1176** The Battle of Legnano demonstrates the effectiveness of spear-armed infantry in tight formation, as Milanese foot soldiers defeat Emperor Frederick Barbarossa's knights.
- **1333** Flemish infantry defeat French knights at Courtrai.
- **1333** At Halidon Hill, King Edward III of England first deploys massed longbowmen, flanking dismounted knights.
- **1476** Swiss Confederacy foot soldiers defeat Charles the Bold at Murten, attacking in columns with long pikes and halberds.

KEY DEVELOPMENT

MEDIEVAL INFANTRY

In the medieval European concept of war, foot soldiers were seen as a low-status, supporting body to mounted knights. In practice, however, when they employed tactics that made best use of their weaponry, infantry often proved decisive on the battlefield.

Most foot soldiers were either citizen militia of prosperous cities, or peasant levies forced into service by their local lords. Correspondingly, the quality of their equipment depended directly upon the money available to finance it. The well-funded infantry from the cities of Flanders – who inflicted a notable defeat upon French knights, at Courtrai in 1302 – were well protected, with mail hauberks (long mail shirts), steel helmets, shields, and gauntlets. Their weapons included bows, crossbows, pikes, and a distinctive staff weapon known as a “goedendag” – a long thick wooden staff tipped with a deadly steel spike – that functioned as both a spear and a club. Such resources were not commonly available to medieval peasant levies,

however, who often entered combat without metal body armour and carrying only the simplest of spears. The success of infantry against mounted troops depended upon them fighting in a disciplined, tight formation on well-chosen ground, with natural obstacles augmented by the digging of ditches or the planting of sharp stakes.

THE CROSSBOW

Bowmen were unquestionably the elite among medieval foot soldiers, and of the weapons used by these infantry, the crossbow was the most sophisticated and powerful. The bolts shot even by earlier models had been able to penetrate mail armour – among their victims was King Richard the

“So great was the **undisciplined** violence... the **living** fell on top of the **dead**, and others falling on top of the living were killed”

GESTA HENRICI, DESCRIBING THE BATTLE OF AGINCOURT, c.1417



► GENOESE CROSSBOWMEN

Crossbowmen from Genoa, Italy, became the most sought-after mercenary soldiers in Europe, employed in particular by the kings of France. They fought in the First Crusade and other land battles as well as naval battles, continuing into the 16th century.

